

A Few Tips on Vi/Vim Editor for Linux Newbies

Inviting all Linux newbies, and even veterans, to try out these tips on using Vi/Vim editor efficiently and productively.



Earlier, most Linux users cut their teeth on Linux with the Vi editor. Those comfortable with using the GUI for Linux may scoff at using Vim for editing, but it does have a few advantages, particularly when working in multi-user systems and also when working on servers. This is because of the Vi editor's efficiency and its minimal use of memory. It is powerful, highly configurable and always available on any system.

I have compiled a few Vi/Vim editor tips, which will make it easier for readers to use it and become more productive.

Abbreviations

Abbreviations can be set, which Vi will expand into full text whenever they are typed in edit mode. An abbreviation can be defined in the command mode by giving the following *EX* command:

```
:ab abbr full text
```

...where *abbr* is an abbreviation for the specified phrase. The expansion is done only when the abbreviation is typed as a word. Avoid repeating the abbreviation in the

defined phrase.

The abbreviation can be disabled by typing the following command:

```
:unab abbr
```

Encryption in Vi

To encrypt any file in the Vi editor, type the following in command mode and press the *Enter* key:

```
:X
```

You will be asked to enter a password twice, which will be used to encrypt the file. The file is now saved in an encrypted format. When opening that file, the password needs to be re-entered. Of course, if you have encrypted a file containing a programming language source code, the file cannot be compiled.

To decrypt the encrypted file, open the file using Vi and type *:X*. Next, hit the *Enter* key twice; then save and exit the Vi editor by typing *:wq*. The file will be saved in the decrypted format.